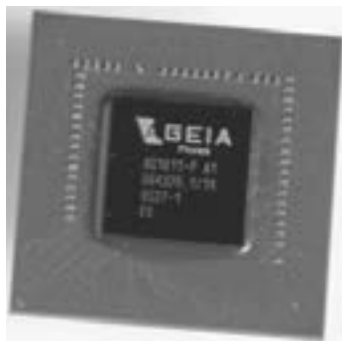


PPUs are not just an idea: Aegia, a relatively small semiconductor company, has already come up with a PPU called PhysX; this is to play a role in the PlayStation 3's number-crunching prowess. Even Nintendo's Revolution is said to have a physics chip.



Aegia's PPU—The PhysX

The existence of PPU is also a boon for game developers, as they would not have to develop and program a separate physics engine—the processor would take care of that part. The emphasis would shift to graphics and maybe other aspects such as AI (Artificial Intelligence), real-time cinematics, or even playing around with touch, smell and taste.

Flights of fancy? Well, not quite: there is some meat to these speculations.

To make games more realistic and to take them to the next level, game developers would need to take a very serious look at the sensory perception aspect.

We have fairly decent visual displays and audio systems. Of course, there can be and will be further developments on the existing technologies. However, what if the display could be a surround experience just as sound is? We might move on from the plain, pixel-based flat-screen displays to surround displays. The gamer's immersion in the game would be augmented—he would have to dodge bullets whizzing in from all directions, in 3D space.

There are companies such as Ethereal Technologies working on such displays.

Volumetric Imaging Systems have come up with a workstation, VIS4D, which allows users to perceive real-time 3D images without